

In the end, it's a character that generates more scrutiny than sympathy for the conundrum she finds herself in. So much so that Sensharma found herself defending the character through the process of what becomes a she-said, she-said narrative.

"I enjoyed playing a toxic man in a woman's body," she says with a laugh. "We tend to exonerate or acquit people on the basis of whether we like or dislike them. It has no bearing on whether they have committed any crime. Just because someone is a woman, queer or from a marginalised or minority community doesn't mean we have to vilify or eulogise them, we just have to humanise them. It's why perhaps a film like this would unfortunately not be in theatres. I think what is popular and massy is uncertainty and not nuance."

That's why Kashyap feels a film like *Accused* could only find an outlet on a streaming platform like Netflix. "I am lucky and thankful that Netflix backed this kind of story in the middle of the other massy entertainers they are making," she says. "They treated it as a prestige project." It's not lost on her that an intense female-centred drama like *Accused* has been created in an atmosphere where mainstream cinema is veering in the opposite direction. Says Kashyap, "Right now, we want a lot of grander-than-life entertainers and spectacle and toxic men romancing beautiful women. That's what the pattern has been, and it's working. I am an eternal optimist, so I hope somebody sees value in our film."

THE RARE OPPORTUNITY TO PLAY AN AMBITIOUS WOMAN WITH A SELFISH STREAK IS WHAT APPEALED TO KONKANA SENSHARMA

What she also hopes viewers take cognisance of is how the central relationship is not seen or defined by a label. "It was deliberate to treat it as just a normal queer relationship. There's no special lens or statement to be made," adds Kashyap. ■

—Suhani Singh



▼ **MARCH 19** | *Sony LIV*

JAZZ CITY

Co-creator Soumik Sen along with Vikramaditya Motwane, created a dark and elegant throwback to studio-era Hindi cinema with Amazon's *Jubilee*. Soumik Sen goes back to '70s Calcutta, packed with music and revolution, in this new series, featuring a mostly Bengali cast.



▼ **MARCH 5** | *Amazon Prime Video*

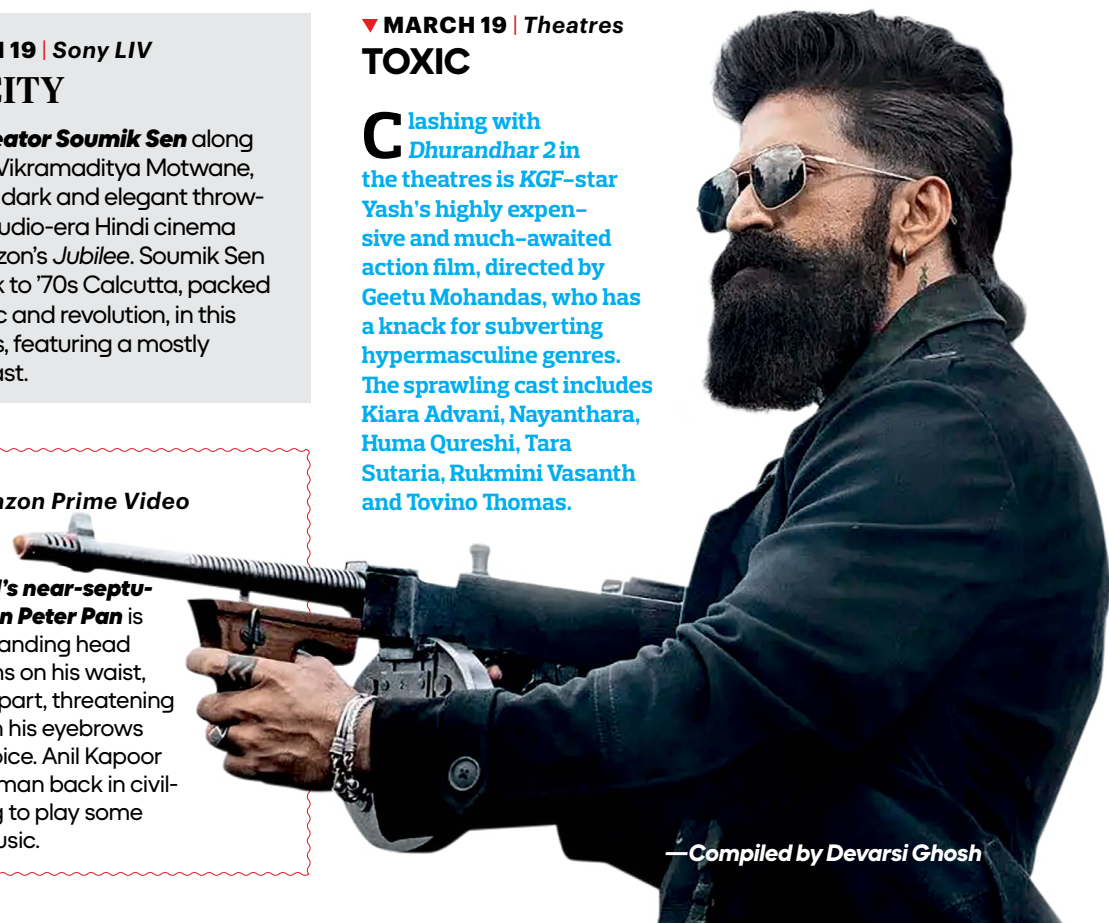
SUBEDAAR

Bollywood's near-septuagenarian Peter Pan is once again standing head held high, arms on his waist, legs spread apart, threatening bad guys with his eyebrows and growly voice. Anil Kapoor is an ex-armyman back in civilian life, aching to play some sweet chin music.

▼ **MARCH 19** | *Theatres*

TOXIC

Clashing with *Dhurandhar 2* in the theatres is *KGF*-star Yash's highly expensive and much-awaited action film, directed by Geetu Mohandas, who has a knack for subverting hypermasculine genres. The sprawling cast includes Kiara Advani, Nayanthara, Huma Qureshi, Tara Sutaria, Rukmini Vasanth and Tovino Thomas.



—Compiled by Devarsi Ghosh